Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
   My life of finding food here at home here, it's not easy for me. Because food stamp is never enough. I have a child here who the doctor told me to be buying some special food like fruits, milk, but because I know this is a child, I try my best to get the required food for him, but not enough for me yet I also need some specific food for my health.
2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
   a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?
      Because of challenges with food, it's been a problem for me. For example, the doctor told me to be eating healthy food for my sicknesses. He told me to not be eating my rice, potatoes, breads, and other things. But because food stamp is never enough, and these foods are cheaper, I still buy eat them because I don't have what else to do.
   b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?
      There's nothing. There's nowhere else I can go to cry for. Food stamp is the one helping me.
   c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?
      CCS there's nothing they helped me with except giving us food stamp. My husband and I don't have jobs. What CCS helped us with was giving us food stamp and paying rent for few months. CCS did not even put us in school to learn English. They never taught us so we can even know small English. So, it becomes hard to find a job when we don't speak any English. My husband has been applying but because he can't speak any English, he does not get jobs. So, because of this, I cannot say that we are well, yet we are living bad. Recently my husband and I went to Refugee Center for help. They told us that we have been receiving $900 in food stamp, but it has been reduced to $800. The organization that helped us with the money for rent and said that we can't use it to buy anything like food at all. You will need to be getting the checks and use it to pay for rent and then the balance that's remaining, we also have to pay it. You can see

we are living bad. Recently, I saw a bill for electricity, what will I use to pay it when we don't have jobs? We don't have anything.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

I can say, what helped me with the most of food stamp, because I can eat on it for some time as the days went forward.

ii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

If I get it, I can use it

Follow up: Do you feel you can manage to find the assistance like food stamp, like if they stop it, can you manage to find it again?

Finding it; how can I know where to pass when I don't know the way. cannot know where to go.

Follow up: Who helped you with food stamp the first time?

At first, I just saw them bringing the food stamp. They brought it after like 2 days of arrival in the US. After a few months, we did not know what it is, but they closed food stamp, and we spent 2 months without eating. My husband went to Refugee center, and they helped him to reapply, then told us to wait for it in the following month. That's how we were able to find it again. Things that are hard for us, we go to refugee center. But I cannot say that we know how to re-apply for it on own.

Follow up: Who gave you food stamp in the beginning?

Our caseworker brought it to us.

Follow up: Did he not teach you how to re-apply for it?

If he had taught us, would we have spent 2 months without eating?

Follow up: You mentioned that you spent 2 months without eating, can you please tell me more what happened, why you spent 2 months without food?

We used to think there's money on food stamp, when we go to do groceries, they tell us that there's no money. 1 month passed by, when we are going to shop, and they tell us that there's no money. Another started, still with no money on the card. We told our friends what's happening to us, and they told us to go to refugee center to ask for help. We went there and they helped us to re-apply for it and told us that they will put money on food stamp but, we had suffered.

Follow up: So, now your food stamp is active?

Yes. They had closed food stamp but now they have re-opened it. They re-opened it when they had reduced it though. So, you can see things are not moving forward but backwards.

Follow up: Are you worried that if food stamp is closed again, you will not manage to re-apply for it?

Yes, I am worried. Because if you don't have someone to speak on your behalf, like us who don't speak English. Sometimes you can find someone to interpret but they interpret wrong things.

iii. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

Yes. I can learn.

Follow up: What are those things you wish to learn from the caseworker regarding food?

Like now, I don't speak English. If I they can teach me English, I can know where to be passing when I'm searching.

Follow up: Can you please explain what you would be searching for?

Things about life so I can find eat. I can know where to be going when I need help, who to ask when I need something like looking for a job, then I can also find myself something to eat.

Follow up: So, after you graduate from CCS, will you manage to re-apply for food stamp?

We will not manage.

Follow up: Why do you think you will not manage?

Because we are in confusion. We don't really understand how things work here. We don't have someone to guide us. We are like in the darkness.

d. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months, if not go to #f below:

Follow up: We have discussed about food stamp already; is there any other programs you have used to help with food? Have you used programs like food bank?

In those months when we did not have food, there's where my husband and kids went. They asked kids how they live. The kids told them the problems we have like not having food, and they told them to go somewhere for free food. Because of confusion and not knowing where the office is, we found someone to take us there and they gave us small food, which also did not make sense. It was just food for one day.

Follow up: So, did you go back to get more food?

I think they had given them for just that one time.

Follow up: How did you know about the program?

There's an office that called my kids and asked them how they live and then they gave them a paper to go to that place. They gave them peas, biscuits and others. There's nothing they brought which made sense that you can cook it.

e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have NOT used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months:
    i. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs like Food Pantries/Other programs during these times?
    We did not know about those programs.
    ii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Have you asked your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you because they help refugees find food resources?
    Every time we go to them, we tell them our problems, like lack of soap, food stamp, so they can guide me on where to go, but they don't tell you anything. They just look at you and keep quiet.

3. Review answers in the Nutrition Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced nutrition insecurity:
    a. You indicated that in the last 12 months, you often/always worried that the food you were able to eat would hurt your health and well-being, can you tell me more?
    What I can explain on this is, based on what the doctors told me on what to eat, I don't do it because I don't have what to do, I still eat everything. For example, the doctors told me that I need to be eating lots of vegetables and eat less rice and potatoes; but because I don't have much, I still eat everything because I don't want to die of hunger.
4. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?
    Like food from our country? Food in America is there. If you have a way to get the food, you can get it. But if you don't have it, you cannot get it. If it's food from our home, it's there, if it's food from here, it's there. If you have a way, you can get any food. But because I don't have a way to get them, I see them with my eyes, but I can't get it.
    b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?
    Like now, there's many stores selling vegetables from my home. Even all stores, now selling all kinds of vegetables from our home. Every type of vegetable from our home, is here.
    c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?
        i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?
        What they did? Me, what I can say that CCS helped me with is food stamp. There's nothing I can say that maybe they showed me where to go or what to do, there's nothing. They also paid rent for me.
        Follow up: Did they help with things like doing grocery shopping, and show you where to do it?

No. CCS left me on my own. They never guided me on where to go or anything like that. Even the caseworker has never reached at my house. Vanessa's mom is the one who brought bus pass cards for us to be using.

Follow up: So, who taught you how to go to the stores to do grocery shopping?

The friends and relatives that I found here are the ones that used to take us to do grocery shopping. CCS never took us or showed us where to buy food.

d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

There's a store that just came that sells vegetables. I have gone there twice.

e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?

   i. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?

No, it's a market that sells vegetables from our home. They sell many of them

Follow up: How did you know about it?

It's my friends that told me that there's a market that only operates during summer. They told me that I should go that they sell vegetables from our home country. So, one day I was just walking around and indeed I saw the market.

"Note: This market she is describing is Sunnyvale farmers market, given the description and her address. Sunnyvale market is located close to her apartment. But she does not know the name of it. She just knows it's a market that sells vegetables from her country".

Follow up: Can you tell me your experience using this market?

This market only operates in the summer. It closes during winter. But we can be buying more vegetables and refrigerate them and use them later.

Follow up: Is there anything else you would like to add? We are finishing.

There's nothing else to ad other than thanking you for taking the time to come and have this discussion with me today. It's good that you are trying to learn the issues happening in refugees. I know that it's not just me who is struggling. For me, the main thing I need is to learn English. For now, I can say thank you. Maybe even our issues can be heard.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview, and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

   The problem affecting us is that we don't have a job. And because we don't have a job, its heard for us to buy things for ourselves. Because waiting for someone to help you takes long.

   Follow up: Sometimes people might have issues accessing food, but they don't use food assistance programs, what do you think hinders them from using them?

Maybe they are also in confusion like me, not knowing about the programs. It's a problem because you don't know where to go. Because if you know there's somewhere you can get help with food, you cannot fail to go there. It's the not knowing that prohibits people from using the programs.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?
   Like the way you found me, you learned how my status is. This can make you understand how I am suffering, which can cause you to learn how other people are suffering.

   Follow up: So, what do you think we can do to make it easier to find the assistance programs? Because sometimes, assistance programs might be there but people won't use them.
   This is caused by the confusion in people. Sometimes I might be hurt, but because I don't how to say it, I can't even manage to ask for help. That's why I'm saying, if we all go to school, and know the language, we can know where things are and how to use them.
   Follow up: You've talked a lot about not going to school, can you explain to me why you didn't go to school?
   CCS never took us to school. They never registered us for school.
   Follow up: Did you try to find other offices to help you with school registration?
   It's CCS office only which we knew. We did not know any other office.
3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?
   CCS needs to know that a person is a person. They took us like animals, not getting close to us so they can know the problems we have. So, what they can do is to get close to people so they can know their problems and how to help them.
4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?
   Since moving here, and feeling like confused, like I'm in a wheelchair, I did not see good things here. CCS did not get close to me to understand my problems. A few days ago, the leasing office came to us saying that we have a balance of $4000. I almost fell with a heart attack. I was asking myself, has CCS not been paying our rent as promised? They asked us for the phone number so they can contact them. I felt this issue was beyond me. I was worried that I will become homeless. I felt my blood pressure moving so high. Luckily, they were able to get a home of CCS and resolved the issue.
   Follow up: So, you would wish for CCS to be close to you so they can know your issues and help?
   Yes.

Thank you!